C13 ACCESSIBILITY AND UNIVERSAL DESIGN | O (MAX : 4 PT)

Intent : Make buildings more accessible, comfortable and usable for people of all backgrounds and abilities.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects integrate universal design and wayfinding principles to accommodate diverse needs and create a more inclusive environment.

Issue : More than one billion people, or about 16% of the global population, live with some type of disability, a health condition and/or impairment a person experiences. [20] Many buildings accommodate a variety of individuals with distinct needs and abilities, yet many are not designed with these diverse requirements in mind.[5,7] Wayfinding, or knowing how to follow a navigational route, is fundamental for autonomy, social integration and community access for all individuals.[4] People who are neurodiverse often lack internal spatial representation and awareness, so they find wayfinding to be particularly challenging and mentally straining.[4] The "fear of getting lost" is the most frequent wayfinding challenge for people with cognitive differences.[5] As a result, individuals tend to stick to routine or well-known trips to avoid the significant stress associated with navigating new spaces.

Solutions : Universal design addresses multiple aspects of a space, including infrastructure, signage and technologies, and seeks to enhance the opportunity for all individuals to exist independently and comfortably in that space.[11] Inclusive spaces and places should be designed to effectively accommodate a diverse range of individuals.[11] There are several solutions that can enhance universal design for all people and address wayfinding challenges. Easily identifiable landmarks, such as sculptures, artwork and distinct architectural elements, can serve as significant points of reference during the navigational process as they are often memorable.[32] Additionally, printed and digital signage provides important information for navigation as well as at points for decision-making.[2] Simple and user-friendly sitemaps that are strategically positioned at key locations throughout a building, including entrances, can quickly help individuals orient and move throughout a space.[11] Moreover, electronic maps can allow individuals to preview routes before engaging in travel.[7, 22] This format is especially helpful for people who are neurodivergent as it offers a more equitable solution to wayfinding and provides individuals with greater control and the ability to choose how they navigate the environment.[22] Lastly, providing wayfinding information in various formats that support a diverse range of cultures and abilities (e.g., braille, different languages) enhances access, allowing all individuals to more easily navigate spaces.[11]

PART 1 INTEGRATE UNIVERSAL DESIGN (MAX : 2 PT)

For All Spaces:

The project considers best practices in universal design to accommodate a diverse range of disabilities and needs by implementing at a minimum one strategy in each of the following categories:[9]

a. Physical access: entry, exit and key interaction points that enable inclusive entrance to the project and strategies that accommodate user changes as needed (e.g., stair-free entrances, step-free egress, operable windows, automatic doors), supporting ease and independence of use.[1,7,10]

b. Developmental and intellectual health, including sensory requirements of people who are neurodiverse: strategies that use color, texture, images and other multi-sensory, visually perceptible information.[1,10,11]

c. Wayfinding: strategies that help individuals intuitively navigate through the project (e.g., signage, tactile maps, symbols, auditory cues, information systems, images, color that considers color blindness, various languages).[10]

d. Policies and programs: strategies that support inclusion and accommodate a diverse range of needs (e.g., diversity and inclusion training, flexible work hours for individuals with disabilities).[1,7,10]

e. Technology: technology (e.g., audio and visual equipment, web access, QR codes) that helps individuals fully utilize a space (e.g., remote access to assist blind or deaf individuals, support for those who do not speak the native language), made available to all occupants at no cost.[1,7,10]

f. Safety: strategies that support easy access to all spaces and amenities and minimize risk of injury, confusion or discomfort (e.g., lighting or clear sightlines to increase feelings of security, service animals, emergency egress plans with highlighted exit points).[1,10,11]

PART 2 B SUPPORT INCLUSIVE INTERIOR NAVIGATION (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

Primary circulation routes meet the following requirements:

a. Include landmarks (e.g., sculptures, water features, artwork, architectural elements) that are:
   1. Positioned at points-of-decision (e.g., intersections, elevators, stairways and emergency exits).[21, 22]
   2. Physically prominent and unique (e.g., due to shape, color, size, historical or cultural significance).[21]

b. Include amenities (e.g., restrooms, quiet areas, drinking water stations, information services) that are:
   1. Within a clear line of sight to another landmark or amenity.
   2. Located consistently throughout the project boundary (e.g., same location on each floor).[21]

c. Include seating areas that are located consistently throughout the project boundary (e.g., same location on each floor).[21]

Note :
This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

PART 3 B SUPPORT INCLUSIVE BUILDING & NEIGHBORHOOD WAYFINDING (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

Information is provided for the building in a way that meets the following requirements:

a. Is present in a physical format (e.g., printed signage, digital display) at the main building entrance and at least one additional functional building entrance, if present.

b. Is available in an electronic format (e.g., website, mobile application).

c. All formats meet the following:

    1. Include audio and/or braille that is compliant with ICC/ANSI A117.1-2003.
    2. Use clear and simple language.[9]
    3. Include more than one language.[9]
    4. Include contact information for assistance services (e.g., screen readers, listening systems, wayfinding apps).

d. All formats include a local amenities directory that meets the following:

    1. Displays the location of at least 8 existing use types (as defined in Appendix V1) relative to the building.
    2. Displays the location of all public transit stops located within a 400 m [0.25 mi] walk distance of the main building entrance, if present.

e. If multiple businesses are present, all formats include a business directory that shows the names of businesses located within the building and their locations (e.g., floor level, room number).

f. All formats include a site map of the building that shows the following, if present, using easily recognizable symbols:

    1. Bathrooms.
    2. Drinking water stations.
    3. Information services.
    4. Areas for resting or sitting.
    5. Wayfinding landmarks.[21]
    6. Accessible pathways.[22]
    7. Emergency exits.

g. All formats include a sensory map of the building that shows the following, if present, using easily recognizable symbols:[9,22]

    1. Restorative spaces.
    2. Loud sounds.
    3. Crowded spaces.
    4. Flashing lights.
    5. Strong smells.

Note :
This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

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